least. Here was I, off to join the Army to defend the country and I couldn't even keep a train ticket safe. Of course, I had to buy another ticket and pay for it out of my pocket money.

The great day dawned, and everyone came to see me off at the station. I had been fully kitted out, including the famous black trunk made to precise dimensions; 100 cm long, 50 cm wide and 25 cm high. These dimensions were so that one could keep one's trousers flat without folding or creasing and so that it would fit exactly under a railway berth. The guard blew his whistle, waved his green flag and I was off on my adventure, my mother fighting hard to hold back her tears. And what an adventure it has been. I was a little over sixteen years old then, in the summer of 1976, and I would retire some forty-six years later, in the summer of 2022.

Unknown to us, it had been decided to increase the intake at the NDA in an attempt to make up for the shortage of officers plaguing the Army. I say attempt, because we were some 12,000 officers short then, and are still about 7000 officers short today, four decades later. The establishment at Khadakwasla having been utilized to capacity, it was decided to open a Wing of the NDA at the Officer Training School (OTS), which had some spare capacity.[1] The OTS was, and is a full-fledged Academy imparting pre-commission training to short-service commission aspirants, who join after having done their graduation from civil universities. This, the NDA Wing had started only six months earlier, with the 55th Course, Spring Term 1976. Notable among the cadets of this course was Cadet Satish Dua, who rose to the rank of Lieutenant General, retiring as the Chief of Integrated Defence Staff to the Chairman Chiefs of Staff Committee (CISC). My stay at the OTS was short-lived. Out of the call letters sent for joining up the main campus, many candidates had failed to turn up, or on

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